I introduced myself as a former first secretary of the High Commission of India at Ottawa and told them I was part of Indira Gandhi's delegation and had come out specially to meet them for old times' sake. A couple of them remembered my name, as I had left Canada only four years ago. I told them that they were not in India where they could say anything or shout any kind of slogans against Indira Gandhi. They were in New York, in front of the UN building, where a number of foreign heads of state or government could observe their conduct. As they could be easily identified by their turbans, I requested them that as true Sikhs, they should observe the maryada (ethics) of their religion and not insult a woman, and that too in public, even though she happened to be the prime minister of India.

After initial protests, they finally agreed that that they would refrain from using foul language in their slogans, posters and placards. Keeping my fingers crossed and hoping that they would keep their promise, I entered the UN building to be close to the UNGA hall where Indira Gandhi was to speak in a short while. I later came to know that they indeed kept that promise. After her speech was over, the prime minister, accompanied by Sonia Gandhi and others, started moving out of the building, but she was stopped in the foyer by a couple of reporters who had questions to ask.

A painful decision

It was time to return to India. As the prime minister's special aircraft was to leave in the forenoon of 2 October, I had booked my seat on an Air India flight from JFK the same afternoon. Fortunately, from our point of view, nothing of the sort that Gary had apprehended had happened. In fact, a few simple and friendly words spoken in an earthy language were all that it took to convince the so-called hard-line Khalistanis in front of the UN building to exercise restraint. Normally, I should have been happy about a task completed satisfactorily. But throughout my return flight I was tormented with the recollection of my interactions with my Sikh friends and contacts during the trip.